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Creating satisficing planners with deep learning

Abstract

Some embodiments of the present invention are directed to a method of choosing the components for a satisficing planner using machine learning (ML) (for example, deep learning (DL)). Some embodiments of the present invention are directed to choosing search algorithm component(s) for a satisficing planner using ML (for example, DL). Some embodiments of the present invention are directed to choosing search refinement components (that is, search boosting component(s) and/or search pruning component(s)) for a satisficing planner using ML (for example, DL).

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Background/Summary

BACKGROUND

- (1) The present invention relates generally to the field of computer-implemented, multi-component satisficing planner assemblies (better known in the art, more simply, as "satisficing planners").
- (2) One known type of planner is called an "optimizing planner." These planners typically have one component. These optimizing planners typically include only a top level component, which represents, essentially, the entirety of the optimizing planners. Optimizing planners are not the focus of this document and are thought not be particularly relevant to the technology described herein.
- (3) Optimizing planners should not be confused with another known technology called "satisficing planners." Satisficing planners typically include multiple components, or algorithms, that are assembled to form the entirety of the satisficing planner. Three component types that are commonly included in currently conventional satisficing planners are: (i) heuristic function; (ii) search

algorithm; (iii) search refinement algorithm. Search refinement algorithms include two subtypes as follows: search boosting algorithms and search pruning algorithms.

(4) It is understood in the art that: (i) not all currently conventional satisficing planners include all of these component types/subtypes; (ii) some currently conventional satisficing planners may include additional component types (that is, types now known or to be developed in the future); (iii) more than one component of a given component type may be included in a single satisficing planner. For example, a single satisficing planner might include: two heuristic functions, three search algorithms, one search boosting algorithm and one search pruning algorithm. It is further understood in the art that the order in which the components are programmed to run is important to the proper performance of the assembled satisficing planner.

(5) It is known that, for each instance of a given component type/subtype in a single satisficing planner, there are typically multiple “component candidates” (that is, different algorithms) to select from in assembling the satisficing planner. Some currently known heuristic function component candidates are as follows: (i) fast forward (FF); (ii) red-black (RB); (iii) causal graph (CG); (iv) Additive; and (v) Landmark Count (LM). Some currently known search algorithm component candidates are as follows: (i) greedy best-first search (GFBS); (ii) weighted $A^*(wA^*)$ where $w=5$; (iii) weighted $A^*(wA^*)$ where $w=3$; (iv) weighted $A^*(wA^*)$ where $w=2$; (v) weighted $A^*(wA^*)$ where $w=1$; and (vi) best-first width search. Some currently known search refinement component candidates are as follows: (i) single queue search boosting algorithm; (ii) dual queue search boosting algorithm with second queue for preferred operators; and (iii) novelty based search pruning algorithm.

(6) The Wikipedia entry for “machine learning” states, in part, as follows (as of 1 Dec. 2021): “Machine learning (ML) is the study of computer algorithms that can improve automatically through experience and by the use of data. It is seen as a part of artificial intelligence. Machine learning algorithms build a model based on sample data, known as training data, in order to make predictions or decisions without being explicitly programmed to do so. Machine learning programs can perform tasks without being explicitly programmed to do so. It involves computers learning from data provided so that they carry out certain tasks. For simple tasks assigned to computers, it is possible to program algorithms telling the machine how to execute all steps required to solve the problem at hand; on the computer's part, no learning is needed. For more advanced tasks, it can be challenging for a human to manually create the needed algorithms. In practice, it can turn out to be more effective to help the machine develop its own algorithm, rather than having human programmers specify every needed step. The discipline of machine learning employs various approaches to teach computers to accomplish tasks where no fully satisfactory algorithm is available. In cases where vast numbers of potential answers exist, one approach is to label some of the correct answers as valid. This can then be used as training data for the computer to improve the algorithm(s) it uses to determine correct answers.” (footnotes omitted)

(7) The Wikipedia entry for “deep learning” states, in part, as follows (as of 1 Dec. 2021): “Deep learning (also known as deep structured learning) is part of a broader family of machine learning methods based on artificial neural networks with representation learning. Learning can be supervised, semi-supervised or unsupervised. Deep-learning architectures such as deep neural networks, deep belief networks, deep reinforcement learning, recurrent neural networks and convolutional neural networks have been applied to fields including computer vision, speech recognition, natural language processing, machine translation, bioinformatics, drug design, medical image analysis, material inspection and board game programs, where they have produced results comparable to and in some cases surpassing human expert performance. Artificial neural networks (ANNs) were inspired by information processing and distributed communication nodes in biological systems. ANNs have various differences from biological brains. Specifically, artificial neural networks tend to be static and symbolic, while the biological brain of most living organisms is dynamic (plastic) and analogue. The adjective ‘deep’ in deep learning refers to the use of

multiple layers in the network. Early work showed that a linear perceptron cannot be a universal classifier, but that a network with a nonpolynomial activation function with one hidden layer of unbounded width can. Deep learning is a modern variation which is concerned with an unbounded number of layers of bounded size, which permits practical application and optimized implementation, while retaining theoretical universality under mild conditions. In deep learning the layers are also permitted to be heterogeneous and to deviate widely from biologically informed connectionist models, for the sake of efficiency, trainability and understandability, whence the ‘structured’ part. Definition[:]. Deep learning is a class of machine learning algorithms that uses multiple layers to progressively extract higher-level features from the raw input. For example, in image processing, lower layers may identify edges, while higher layers may identify the concepts relevant to a human such as digits or letters or faces. Most modern deep learning models are based on artificial neural networks, specifically convolutional neural networks (CNN)s, although they can also include propositional formulas or latent variables organized layer-wise in deep generative models such as the nodes in deep belief networks and deep Boltzmann machines. In deep learning, each level learns to transform its input data into a slightly more abstract and composite representation. In an image recognition application, the raw input may be a matrix of pixels; the first representational layer may abstract the pixels and encode edges; the second layer may compose and encode arrangements of edges; the third layer may encode a nose and eyes; and the fourth layer may recognize that the image contains a face. Importantly, a deep learning process can learn which features to optimally place in which level on its own. This does not completely eliminate the need for hand-tuning; for example, varying numbers of layers and layer sizes can provide different degrees of abstraction. The word ‘deep’ in ‘deep learning’ refers to the number of layers through which the data is transformed.” (footnotes omitted))

(8) One known approach to prediction of planner performance based on deep learning is presented in the published article “Deep Learning for Cost-Optimal Planning: Task-Dependent Planner Selection,” SIEVERS, et al., The Thirty-Third AAAI Conference on Artificial Intelligence (AAAI-19), Vol. 33 No. 01: AAAI-19, IAAI-19, EAAI-20, Jul. 17, 2019 (hereinafter, the “Deep Learning for Cost-Optimal Planning article).

SUMMARY

(9) According to an aspect of the present invention, there is a method, computer program product and/or system that performs the following operations (not necessarily in the following order): (i) receive a planner application data set that includes information indicative of contexts in which a newly-designed satisficing planner is expected to be applied; (ii) receiving a machine learning algorithm that has been trained to design satisficing planners; and (iii) applying the machine learning algorithm to the planner application data set to obtain a newly-designed satisficing planner design, with the newly-designed satisficing planner design including information indicative of a plurality of satisficing planner components to be included in the newly-designed satisficing planner design and an order in which the satisficing components are to be run.

(10) According to an aspect of the present invention, there is a method, computer program product and/or system that performs the following operations (not necessarily in the following order): (i) receive a planner application data set that includes information indicative of contexts in which a newly-designed satisficing planner is expected to be applied; (ii) receiving a machine learning algorithm that has been trained to determine search algorithm component(s) for satisficing planners; and (iii) applying the machine learning algorithm to the planner application data set to determine search algorithm component(s) for use in a newly-designed satisficing planner design.

(11) According to an aspect of the present invention, there is a method, computer program product and/or system that performs the following operations (not necessarily in the following order): (i) receive a planner application data set that includes information indicative of contexts in which a newly-designed satisficing planner is expected to be applied; (ii) receiving a machine learning algorithm that has been trained to determine search algorithm component(s) for satisficing

planners; and (iii) applying the machine learning algorithm to the planner application data set to determine search refinement component(s) for use in a newly-designed satisficing planner design.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

- (1) FIG. 1 is a block diagram view of a first embodiment of a system according to the present invention;
- (2) FIG. 2 is a flowchart showing a first embodiment method performed, at least in part, by the first embodiment system;
- (3) FIG. 3 is a block diagram showing a machine logic (for example, software) portion of the first embodiment system.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(4) Some embodiments of the present invention are directed to a method of choosing the components for a satisficing planner using machine learning (ML) (for example, deep learning (DL)). Some embodiments of the present invention are directed to choosing search algorithm component(s) for a satisficing planner using ML (for example, DL). Some embodiments of the present invention are directed to choosing search refinement components (that is, search boosting component(s) and/or search pruning component(s)) for a satisficing planner using ML (for example, DL). This Detailed Description section is divided into the following subsections: (i) The Hardware and Software Environment; (ii) Example Embodiment; (iii) Further Comments and/or Embodiments; and (iv) Definitions.

I. The Hardware and Software Environment

- (5) The present invention may be a system, a method, and/or a computer program product at any possible technical detail level of integration. The computer program product may include a computer readable storage medium (or media) having computer readable program instructions thereon for causing a processor to carry out aspects of the present invention. The computer program product may include a computer readable storage medium (or media) having computer readable program instructions thereon for causing a processor to carry out aspects of the present invention.
- (6) The computer readable storage medium can be a tangible device that can retain and store instructions for use by an instruction execution device. The computer readable storage medium may be, for example, but is not limited to, an electronic storage device, a magnetic storage device, an optical storage device, an electromagnetic storage device, a semiconductor storage device, or any suitable combination of the foregoing. A non-exhaustive list of more specific examples of the computer readable storage medium includes the following: a portable computer diskette, a hard disk, a random access memory (RAM), a read-only memory (ROM), an erasable programmable read-only memory (EPROM or Flash memory), a static random access memory (SRAM), a portable compact disc read-only memory (CD-ROM), a digital versatile disk (DVD), a memory stick, a floppy disk, a mechanically encoded device such as punch-cards or raised structures in a groove having instructions recorded thereon, and any suitable combination of the foregoing. A computer readable storage medium, as used herein, is not to be construed as being transitory signals per se, such as radio waves or other freely propagating electromagnetic waves, electromagnetic waves propagating through a waveguide or other transmission media (for example, light pulses passing through a fiber-optic cable), or electrical signals transmitted through a wire.
- (7) A “storage device” is hereby defined to be anything made or adapted to store computer code in a manner so that the computer code can be accessed by a computer processor. A storage device typically includes a storage medium, which is the material in, or on, which the data of the computer code is stored. A single “storage device” may have: (i) multiple discrete portions that are spaced apart, or distributed (for example, a set of six solid state storage devices respectively located in six

laptop computers that collectively store a single computer program); and/or (ii) may use multiple storage media (for example, a set of computer code that is partially stored in as magnetic domains in a computer's non-volatile storage and partially stored in a set of semiconductor switches in the computer's volatile memory). The term "storage medium" should be construed to cover situations where multiple different types of storage media are used.

(8) Computer readable program instructions described herein can be downloaded to respective computing/processing devices from a computer readable storage medium or to an external computer or external storage device via a network, for example, the Internet, a local area network, a wide area network and/or a wireless network. The network may comprise copper transmission cables, optical transmission fibers, wireless transmission, routers, firewalls, switches, gateway computers and/or edge servers. A network adapter card or network interface in each computing/processing device receives computer readable program instructions from the network and forwards the computer readable program instructions for storage in a computer readable storage medium within the respective computing/processing device.

(9) Computer readable program instructions for carrying out operations of the present invention may be assembler instructions, instruction-set-architecture (ISA) instructions, machine instructions, machine dependent instructions, microcode, firmware instructions, state-setting data, or either source code or object code written in any combination of one or more programming languages, including an object oriented programming language such as Smalltalk, C++ or the like, and conventional procedural programming languages, such as the "C" programming language or similar programming languages. The computer readable program instructions may execute entirely on the user's computer, partly on the user's computer, as a stand-alone software package, partly on the user's computer and partly on a remote computer or entirely on the remote computer or server. In the latter scenario, the remote computer may be connected to the user's computer through any type of network, including a local area network (LAN) or a wide area network (WAN), or the connection may be made to an external computer (for example, through the Internet using an Internet Service Provider). In some embodiments, electronic circuitry including, for example, programmable logic circuitry, field-programmable gate arrays (FPGA), or programmable logic arrays (PLA) may execute the computer readable program instructions by utilizing state information of the computer readable program instructions to personalize the electronic circuitry, in order to perform aspects of the present invention.

(10) Aspects of the present invention are described herein with reference to flowchart illustrations and/or block diagrams of methods, apparatus (systems), and computer program products according to embodiments of the invention. It will be understood that each block of the flowchart illustrations and/or block diagrams, and combinations of blocks in the flowchart illustrations and/or block diagrams, can be implemented by computer readable program instructions.

(11) These computer readable program instructions may be provided to a processor of a general purpose computer, special purpose computer, or other programmable data processing apparatus to produce a machine, such that the instructions, which execute via the processor of the computer or other programmable data processing apparatus, create means for implementing the functions/acts specified in the flowchart and/or block diagram block or blocks. These computer readable program instructions may also be stored in a computer readable storage medium that can direct a computer, a programmable data processing apparatus, and/or other devices to function in a particular manner, such that the computer readable storage medium having instructions stored therein comprises an article of manufacture including instructions which implement aspects of the function/act specified in the flowchart and/or block diagram block or blocks.

(12) The computer readable program instructions may also be loaded onto a computer, other programmable data processing apparatus, or other device to cause a series of operational steps to be performed on the computer, other programmable apparatus or other device to produce a computer implemented process, such that the instructions which execute on the computer, other

programmable apparatus, or other device implement the functions/acts specified in the flowchart and/or block diagram block or blocks.

(13) The flowchart and block diagrams in the Figures illustrate the architecture, functionality, and operation of possible implementations of systems, methods, and computer program products according to various embodiments of the present invention. In this regard, each block in the flowchart or block diagrams may represent a module, segment, or portion of instructions, which comprises one or more executable instructions for implementing the specified logical function(s). In some alternative implementations, the functions noted in the block may occur out of the order noted in the figures. For example, two blocks shown in succession may, in fact, be executed substantially concurrently, or the blocks may sometimes be executed in the reverse order, depending upon the functionality involved. It will also be noted that each block of the block diagrams and/or flowchart illustration, and combinations of blocks in the block diagrams and/or flowchart illustration, can be implemented by special purpose hardware-based systems that perform the specified functions or acts or carry out combinations of special purpose hardware and computer instructions.

(14) As shown in FIG. 1, networked computers system **100** is an embodiment of a hardware and software environment for use with various embodiments of the present invention. Networked computers system **100** includes: server subsystem **102** (sometimes herein referred to, more simply, as subsystem **102**); client subsystems **104**, **106**, **108**, **110**, **112**; and communication network **114**. Server subsystem **102** includes: server computer **200**; communication unit **202**; processor set **204**; input/output (I/O) interface set **206**; memory **208**; persistent storage **210**; display **212**; external device(s) **214**; random access memory (RAM) **230**; cache **232**; and program **300**.

(15) Subsystem **102** may be a laptop computer, tablet computer, netbook computer, personal computer (PC), a desktop computer, a personal digital assistant (PDA), a smart phone, or any other type of computer (see definition of “computer” in Definitions section, below). Program **300** is a collection of machine readable instructions and/or data that is used to create, manage and control certain software functions that will be discussed in detail, below, in the Example Embodiment subsection of this Detailed Description section.

(16) Subsystem **102** is capable of communicating with other computer subsystems via communication network **114**. Network **114** can be, for example, a local area network (LAN), a wide area network (WAN) such as the Internet, or a combination of the two, and can include wired, wireless, or fiber optic connections. In general, network **114** can be any combination of connections and protocols that will support communications between server and client subsystems.

(17) Subsystem **102** is shown as a block diagram with many double arrows. These double arrows (no separate reference numerals) represent a communications fabric, which provides communications between various components of subsystem **102**. This communications fabric can be implemented with any architecture designed for passing data and/or control information between processors (such as microprocessors, communications and network processors, etc.), system memory, peripheral devices, and any other hardware components within a computer system. For example, the communications fabric can be implemented, at least in part, with one or more buses.

(18) Memory **208** and persistent storage **210** are computer-readable storage media. In general, memory **208** can include any suitable volatile or non-volatile computer-readable storage media. It is further noted that, now and/or in the near future: (i) external device(s) **214** may be able to supply, some or all, memory for subsystem **102**; and/or (ii) devices external to subsystem **102** may be able to provide memory for subsystem **102**. Both memory **208** and persistent storage **210**: (i) store data in a manner that is less transient than a signal in transit; and (ii) store data on a tangible medium (such as magnetic or optical domains). In this embodiment, memory **208** is volatile storage, while persistent storage **210** provides nonvolatile storage. The media used by persistent storage **210** may also be removable. For example, a removable hard drive may be used for persistent storage **210**. Other examples include optical and magnetic disks, thumb drives, and smart cards that are inserted

into a drive for transfer onto another computer-readable storage medium that is also part of persistent storage **210**.

(19) Communications unit **202** provides for communications with other data processing systems or devices external to subsystem **102**. In these examples, communications unit **202** includes one or more network interface cards. Communications unit **202** may provide communications through the use of either or both physical and wireless communications links. Any software modules discussed herein may be downloaded to a persistent storage device (such as persistent storage **210**) through a communications unit (such as communications unit **202**).

(20) I/O interface set **206** allows for input and output of data with other devices that may be connected locally in data communication with server computer **200**. For example, I/O interface set **206** provides a connection to external device set **214**. External device set **214** will typically include devices such as a keyboard, keypad, a touch screen, and/or some other suitable input device. External device set **214** can also include portable computer-readable storage media such as, for example, thumb drives, portable optical or magnetic disks, and memory cards. Software and data used to practice embodiments of the present invention, for example, program **300**, can be stored on such portable computer-readable storage media. I/O interface set **206** also connects in data communication with display **212**. Display **212** is a display device that provides a mechanism to display data to a user and may be, for example, a computer monitor or a smart phone display screen.

(21) In this embodiment, program **300** is stored in persistent storage **210** for access and/or execution by one or more computer processors of processor set **204**, usually through one or more memories of memory **208**. It will be understood by those of skill in the art that program **300** may be stored in a more highly distributed manner during its run time and/or when it is not running. Program **300** may include both machine readable and performable instructions and/or substantive data (that is, the type of data stored in a database). In this particular embodiment, persistent storage **210** includes a magnetic hard disk drive. To name some possible variations, persistent storage **210** may include a solid state hard drive, a semiconductor storage device, read-only memory (ROM), erasable programmable read-only memory (EPROM), flash memory, or any other computer-readable storage media that is capable of storing program instructions or digital information.

(22) The programs described herein are identified based upon the application for which they are implemented in a specific embodiment of the invention. However, it should be appreciated that any particular program nomenclature herein is used merely for convenience, and thus the invention should not be limited to use solely in any specific application identified and/or implied by such nomenclature.

(23) The descriptions of the various embodiments of the present invention have been presented for purposes of illustration, but are not intended to be exhaustive or limited to the embodiments disclosed. Many modifications and variations will be apparent to those of ordinary skill in the art without departing from the scope and spirit of the described embodiments. The terminology used herein was chosen to best explain the principles of the embodiments, the practical application or technical improvement over technologies found in the marketplace, or to enable others of ordinary skill in the art to understand the embodiments disclosed herein.

II. Example Embodiment

(24) As shown in FIG. 1, networked computers system **100** is an environment in which an example method according to the present invention can be performed. As shown in FIG. 2, flowchart **250** shows an example method according to the present invention. As shown in FIG. 3, program **300** performs or controls performance of at least some of the method operations of flowchart **250**. This method and associated software will now be discussed, over the course of the following paragraphs, with extensive reference to the blocks of FIGS. 1, 2 and 3.

(25) Processing begins at operation S255, where input module (“mod”) **302** receives a planner application data set that includes information indicative of contexts in which a newly-designed

satisficing planner is expected to be applied. In this example: (i) the data set is received from client subsystem **104** through network **114**; (ii) the data set includes a previous iteration of a satisficing planner design that has been used, and had its usage monitored, in similar contexts; and (iii) the previously used planner includes multiple components of several different component types/subtypes and will be used as a basis for designing a newly-designed satisficing planner design. (26) Processing proceeds to operation **S260**, where processing mod **304** receives deep learning (DL) algorithm **306** that has been trained to design satisficing planners. In this embodiment, the deep learning architecture and conceptual approach set forth in the “Deep Learning for Cost-Optimal Planning” article is used as the basis of the deep learning algorithm. See, especially, the architecture shown in FIG. 2 of this article. Alternative and/or additionally, in performing operation **S260**, some embodiments may: (i) add more hidden layers to perform operation **S260**; (ii) use other architectures for image convolution (now known or to be developed in the future); and/or (iii) use graph neural networks (GNNs).

(27) Processing proceeds to operation **S265**, where processing mod **304** applies DL algorithm **306** to the planner application data set to obtain a newly-designed satisficing planner design (which will be instantiated in the next operation in the form of satisficing planner code **310**). In this example, the newly-designed satisficing planner design includes three component types as follows: (i) heuristic function type (two components); (ii) search algorithm type (two components); and (iii) search refinement type (two components). Accordingly, there is a total of six (6) components in the new design. The newly-designed satisficing planner design also specifies an order in which the six (6) satisficing components are to be run.

(28) Processing proceeds to operation **S270**, where an actual instantiation of code for implementing the newly-designed satisficing planner is instantiated as satisficing planner code **310**. More specifically, code **310**, according to the newly-designed satisficing planner design, includes six selected component candidates: (i) first selected heuristic function **312** (in this example, a red-black component candidate is chosen for component **312** from among the heuristic function candidates listed, above, in the Background section); (ii) second selected heuristic function **314** (in this example, an additive component candidate); (iii) first selected search algorithm **316** (in this example, a greedy best-first search (GFBS) algorithm); (iv) second selected search algorithm **318** (in this example, a best-first width search algorithm); (v) selected search boosting algorithm **320**; and (vi) selected search pruning algorithm **322**.

(29) Processing proceeds to operation **S275**, where output mod **308** sends a copy of code **310** out through network **114** to client subsystems **104** and **110**, where it will be used to perform various satisficing planner type functions.

III. Further Comments and/or Embodiments

(30) An embodiment of a method of creating a satisficing planner with deep learning according to the present invention includes the following operations (not necessarily in the following order): (i) the total time bound is provided in advance; (ii) the learning is performed to estimate the quality of the solution and the time performance of each individual planner; (iii) the training data is obtained by running the planners on existing planning tasks, with various bounds on solution costs as input; (iv) the trained network is used as a successor generator for traversing the possible sequences of invocations of various planners; and (v) the traversal results in a sequence of invocations of planners, which constitutes the created satisficing planner.

(31) Some embodiments of the present invention may include one, or more, of the following features, advantages, operations and/or characteristics: (i) train a single network for all possible planning domains, to predict a time and quality of solution per algorithm and planning task pair; (ii) the predicted values are then used to guide a search; (iii) the outcome of the search is a sequence of algorithms that can be applied to the planning task to solve it; and/or (iv) a heuristic search-based solution to numeric planning.

(32) Some embodiments of the present invention may include one, or more, of the following

features, advantages, operations and/or characteristics: (i) provides a technique that works well for many planning problems; (ii) affords flexibility in choosing a next iteration of a satisficing planner, based on the performance in the previous iterations of similar satisficing planner(s); (iii) given a planning task, generate a sequence of calls to planners, tailored to that specific task; (iv) the sequence is generated using a traversal through the space of sequences of iterations, using a neural network for a successor generation, predicting for a given task and the bound on solution quality, the outcome solution quality and the total time for the iteration; (v) the network is trained using performance data of the possible planners used for each single iteration on existing planning benchmark sets; and/or (vi) the search aims at finding a sequence of iterations that results in the best predicted solution quality, while keeping the total predicted time under the given bound.

(33) An embodiment of a method of creating a satisficing planner with deep learning according to the present invention includes the following operations (not necessarily in the following order): (i) chooses a collection of planners to use in iterations by running the planners on existing planning tasks to obtain their performance data and reiterating with decreasing bounds from previously found solutions; (iii) given the data, train a network to predict for a planning task and a bound the quality of solution obtained and the time performance estimate; (iv) for a given planning task, traverse the space of sequences of planner iterations; (v) each search node represents a sequence of planner iterations, so that each node accumulates the total time so far and keeps the estimated solution quality while pruning nodes with accumulated total time beyond the given bound; and (vi) create successor nodes using the trained network for successor generation, using the estimated solution quality and the planning task as input.

(34) An embodiment of a method of creating a satisficing planner with deep learning according to the present invention includes the following operations (not necessarily in the following order): (i) the total time bound is provided in advance; (ii) the learning is performed to estimate the quality of the solution and the time performance of each individual planner; (iii) the training data is obtained by running the planners on existing planning tasks, with various bounds on solution costs as input; (iv) the trained network is used as a successor generator for traversing the possible sequences of invocations of various planners; and/or (v) the traversal results in a sequence of invocations of planners, which constitutes the created satisficing planner.

(35) Some embodiments of the present invention may include one, or more, of the following features, advantages, operations and/or characteristics: (i) where the various bounds for generating training data are obtained from the quality of the solution found in the previous iteration; (ii) where the sequences are pruned based on the accumulated predicted total time; (iii) where the representation of a planning task is an image or a graph; and/or (iv) improving planner performance allows to better support a variety of use cases.

IV. Definitions

(36) Present invention: should not be taken as an absolute indication that the subject matter described by the term “present invention” is covered by either the claims as they are filed, or by the claims that may eventually issue after patent prosecution; while the term “present invention” is used to help the reader to get a general feel for which disclosures herein are believed to potentially be new, this understanding, as indicated by use of the term “present invention,” is tentative and provisional and subject to change over the course of patent prosecution as relevant information is developed and as the claims are potentially amended.

(37) Embodiment: see definition of “present invention” above-similar cautions apply to the term “embodiment.”

(38) And/or: inclusive or; for example, A, B “and/or” C means that at least one of A or B or C is true and applicable.

(39) Including/include/includes: unless otherwise explicitly noted, means “including but not necessarily limited to.”

(40) Module/Sub-Module: any set of hardware, firmware and/or software that operatively works to

do some kind of function, without regard to whether the module is: (i) in a single local proximity; (ii) distributed over a wide area; (iii) in a single proximity within a larger piece of software code; (iv) located within a single piece of software code; (v) located in a single storage device, memory or medium; (vi) mechanically connected; (vii) electrically connected; and/or (viii) connected in data communication.

(41) Computer: any device with significant data processing and/or machine readable instruction reading capabilities including, but not limited to: desktop computers, mainframe computers, laptop computers, field-programmable gate array (FPGA) based devices, smart phones, personal digital assistants (PDAs), body-mounted or inserted computers, embedded device style computers, application-specific integrated circuit (ASIC) based devices.

Claims

1. A computer-implemented method comprising: receiving a planner application data set that includes information indicative of contexts in which a newly-designed satisficing planner is expected to be applied; receiving a machine learning algorithm that has been trained to design satisficing planners; and applying the machine learning algorithm to the planner application data set to obtain a newly-designed satisficing planner design, with the newly-designed satisficing planner design including the information indicative of a plurality of satisficing planner components to be included in the newly-designed satisficing planner design and an order in which the satisficing components are to be run, wherein the applying of the machine learning algorithm includes the following operations: for each given satisficing planner component of the plurality of satisficing planner components, determining a component type from a plurality of component types for the given satisficing planner component, wherein the plurality of component types are selected from a list consisting of heuristic function types, search algorithm types, and refinement algorithm types, and wherein the refinement algorithm types comprise a search boosting component subtype and a search pruning component; and for each given satisficing planner component of the plurality of satisficing planner components, determining a component candidate, from among a plurality of component candidates, of the determined component type of the given satisficing planner component.
2. The method of claim 1, wherein the machine learning algorithm is a deep learning algorithm that includes a plurality of layers.
3. The method of claim 2, wherein the plurality of layers includes a plurality of hidden layers.
4. The method of claim 1, wherein: the planner application data set includes a previously used satisficing planner design; and the application of the machine learning algorithm uses the previously used satisficing planner as a basis for the newly-designed satisficing planner design.
5. The method of claim 1, wherein the newly-designed satisficing planner design includes: at least one satisficing planner component of the heuristic function type; at least one satisficing planner component of the search algorithm type; and at least one satisficing planner component of the search refinement type.
6. A computer system comprising: one or more processors, one or more computer-readable memories, one or more computer-readable tangible storage medium, and program instructions stored on at least one of the one or more tangible storage medium for execution by at least one of the one or more processors via at least one of the one or more memories, wherein the computer system is capable of performing a method comprising: receiving a planner application data set that includes information indicative of contexts in which a newly-designed satisficing planner is expected to be applied; receiving a machine learning algorithm that has been trained to design satisficing planners; and applying the machine learning algorithm to the planner application data set to obtain a newly-designed satisficing planner design, with the newly-designed satisficing planner design including the information indicative of a plurality of satisficing planner components

to be included in the newly-designed satisficing planner design and an order in which the satisficing components are to be run, wherein the applying of the machine learning algorithm includes the following operations: for each given satisficing planner component of the plurality of satisficing planner components, determining a component type from a plurality of component types for the given satisficing planner component, wherein the plurality of component types are selected from a list consisting of heuristic function types, search algorithm types, and refinement algorithm types, and wherein the refinement algorithm types comprise a search boosting component subtype and a search pruning component; and for each given satisficing planner component of the plurality of satisficing planner components, determining a component candidate, from among a plurality of component candidates, of the determined component type of the given satisficing planner component.

7. The computer system of claim 6 wherein the machine learning algorithm is a deep learning algorithm that includes a plurality of layers.

8. The computer system of claim 7 where the plurality of layers includes a plurality of hidden layers.

9. A computer program product comprising: one or more computer-readable tangible storage media and program instructions stored on at least one of the one or more tangible storage media, the program instructions executable by a processor to cause the processor to perform a method comprising: receiving a planner application data set that includes information indicative of contexts in which a newly-designed satisficing planner is expected to be applied; receiving a machine learning algorithm that has been trained to design satisficing planners; and applying the machine learning algorithm to the planner application data set to obtain a newly-designed satisficing planner design, with the newly-designed satisficing planner design including the information indicative of a plurality of satisficing planner components to be included in the newly-designed satisficing planner design and an order in which the satisficing components are to be run, wherein the applying of the machine learning algorithm includes the following operations: for each given satisficing planner component of the plurality of satisficing planner components, determining a component type from a plurality of component types for the given satisficing planner component, wherein the plurality of component types are selected from a list consisting of heuristic function types, search algorithm types, and refinement algorithm types, and wherein the refinement algorithm types comprise a search boosting component subtype and a search pruning component; and for each given satisficing planner component of the plurality of satisficing planner components, determining a component candidate, from among a plurality of component candidates, of the determined component type of the given satisficing planner component.

10. The computer program product of claim 9 wherein the machine learning algorithm is a deep learning algorithm that includes a plurality of layers.

11. The computer program product of claim 10, wherein the plurality of layers includes a plurality of hidden layers.
